

IAS PRELIMS/MAINS

Ecology & Environment

A stylized illustration of a green city skyline with various skyscrapers, wind turbines, and a sun, set against a light green background with a globe-like shape.

A COMPREHENSIVE COVERAGE

MODULE - 8

WETLANDS

WETLANDS

- Wetlands are transition zones or ecotones between terrestrial and aquatic ecosystems.
- Wetlands are those land areas where the soil is saturated with water.
- Waterlogged soil (Hydric Soil), adapted plant life (hydrophytes- Moisture loving plants) are the chief characteristics of wetlands.



MARSHES



SWAMPS

Marshes and Swamps are the two main natural types of wetlands.

MARSH

- A marsh is a wetland frequently or continually filled with water. Marshes can be found on the coast and inland, so can be either freshwater or saltwater.
- Marshes are characterized by grassy, soft vegetation that grows in the soggy soil conditions.



SWAMP

- A swamp is any wetland dominated by woody plants and several feet of water.
- The saturated ground and standing water provide a favorable environment for water-tolerant shrubs and trees.



WETLANDS - CLASSIFICATION

Wetlands can be both Inland and Coastal –

- **Inland Wetlands** : Marsh, Swamp, Peat lands, shallow ponds, etc.
- **Coastal Wetlands** : Estuaries, Coastal lagoons, Salt marshes (Caused by tides) etc.

PEATLANDS

- Peatlands are a type of wetlands.
- A peatland is an area with a naturally accumulated peat layer.
- Peat is the accumulation of organic material (remains of plants) that has been formed at a waterlogged location.
- Peatland is an area where litter deposition exceeds anaerobic decomposition (i.e., in the absence of oxygen)



SALT MARSHES

Salt marshes are coastal wetlands that are flooded and drained by salt water brought in by the tides. These areas are dominated by salt tolerant plants.

Salt marshes are marshy areas and the soil contains peat.



ESTUARY

- Estuaries are wetlands.
- Estuaries are home to unique plant and animal communities that have adapted to brackish water which is a mixture of fresh water from the land and salty seawater.



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